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J3. Most Common Types of Student Visas

For higher education students

For students coming to France to study for 4 months–1 year to pursue higher education studies at the bachelor and master’s level, there are two types of visa: the **VLS-TS Student Visa** and the **VLS-T Student Visa**. There are important differences between the two types, including whether the visa is renewable and whether students can work while in France. Doctoral students must apply for a different visa, the “**researcher-talent passport**,” and they have to hold the equivalent of a master’s degree to be eligible.

The VLS-TS “Long-Stay” Student Visa (*Visa long séjour valant titre de séjour*)

- A VLS-TS Student Visa can not only be used to enter France but is also valid as a residence permit for students in France for 3 to 12 months. It can be renewed unlike the next type of visa we will discuss (the VLS-T Temporary Student Visa).
- Students must first enrol in their chosen institution and then apply for this visa from their home countries using [this French government visa site](#).
- The VLS-TS Student Visa must be validated within three months of a student’s arrival in France. The validation process is entirely digital at [this website](#).
- VLS-TS holders can:

- travel freely in all the 26 countries in the Schengen Area (for no more than 90 days over any period of 180 consecutive days);
 - work 964 hours per year (i.e., 20 hours per week)
 - use **VISALE**, the free security deposit service for students;
 - receive a rental subsidy from the CAF, the family allowance fund (*caisse d'allocations familiales*),
 - extend their stay beyond the period of validity of the issued residence permit.
- VLS-TS students wishing to continue their studies after their visa expires must apply for a multi-annual residence permit (*carte de séjour pluriannuelle*) and complete the application two months before the current VLS-TS expires. To be eligible for renewal, students must be able to prove, as they did at their initial application, that they:
 - are enrolled in a French institution of higher education
 - have monthly resources of at least 615 euros.

The VLS-T Student (*étudiant*) Visa

This visa is also for students studying higher education in France for 4 to 12 months but **it cannot be renewed**. VLS-T students do not have to validate the visa in a “prefecture” at arrival.

- VLS-T students can:
 - travel freely in countries within the Schengen Area
 - Register in the French social security [<https://www.campusfrance.org/en/registering-to-social-security>] which will allow them to be partly reimbursed for medical expenses.
- VLS-T students **cannot**:
 - work during their studies;
 - benefit from VISALE;
 - receive a CAF housing subsidy;
 - extend their stay beyond the validity of issued residence permits.

Visas for other study purposes

Internship VLS-TS: Long-Stay Internships (*long séjour valant titre de séjour mention stagiaire*)

An internship VLS-TS allows students to complete an internship in France for **more than three months**.

- Upon expiry, and if students wish to stay longer, they can request a temporary internship residency permit.
- The internship must be part of professional training and take place in a company or public hospital.
- If the internship is less than three months, students need to apply for a short-stay visa (see below).
- Students must validate this visa at the **Office Français de l'Immigration et de l'Intégration**

Researcher-Talent Passport Long-Stay Visa

The “researcher-talent passport” (*passeport talent-chercheur*) long-stay visa allows students to pursue a doctorate, conduct research or teach in France, and to work under the conditions outlined in a “hosting agreement.” Researchers on this visa are not permitted to seek employment outside of their hosting agreement.

It may be renewed in the form of a multi-year residency permit. Spouses and dependent children of students with this visa can accompany the student through the **famille accompagnant** process and spouses may work while in France. **Visit Campus France** for more information. In addition, **EURAXESS FRANCE** is an excellent resource for researchers coming to France.

Short-stay Visa for 0–3 months

For students who are not from the European Economic Area, Iceland, Norway, Liechtenstein or Switzerland but who are interested in attending a short-term study programme in France for less than 90 days, a short-stay visa is likely required. **This type of visa** will allow most students to attend:

- a language course;
- a course as a student;
- a university entrance exam;
- a university entrance interview;
- training as a student;

- caregiver training (young *au pair*);
- school as a minor.

“Student-in-Competition” Visa (*étudiant concours*)

The “**student-in-competition**” **short-stay visa** is for non-European students and is only valid in France. It allows students to come to France to sit an exam or an admission interview at a higher education institute. Should the student pass the exam or admissions test, with this visa they are able to request a student residency permit from the Prefecture without having to return to their country of residence. If they fail, however, they must leave France as soon as the results are published.

Schengen Short-stay Visa

The **Schengen Short-stay visa** allows students/visitors to enter and remain in a country in the Schengen area, including France, for a maximum period of 90 days. It may apply to a single, uninterrupted stay of 90 days or several shorter stays with a cumulative length of 90 days. ***The Schengen Short-stay visa is ideal for students wishing to travel, take a short training programme, or to complete an internship.***

Alternatively, the **Schengen Single Entrance Short-stay Visa** is only valid for one trip. It does not authorise holders to live in France (unlike a long-stay visa). After the 90 days the visa holder must leave the Schengen area. The Schengen Short-Stay visa is renewable but previous holders must wait six months to submit a new request.

Visas for School-going Minors

There are both **short and long-stay school-going minor visa options** for this level of study. These visas are for foreign minors under the age of 18 who wish to study in France and whose parents do not live in France. (If a student’s parents reside in France, this type of visa is not required.) The long-stay visa for school-going minors is also applicable for youth aged between 16 and 18 wishing to study for a period exceeding 90 days in a language or sports centre.

As with other visa applicants, parents or guardians must provide supporting documentation about the child’s enrolment in a French school, his/her school reports from the previous year and a certificate about his/her

knowledge of the French language, details about his/her accommodation in France, financial resources and insurance, parental authorisation and the contact details of a guarantor in France.

Post-study Travel Visas

Students graduating from a French higher education institute with a master's degree can stay on in France after their studies for tourism and/or professional reasons with a Travel or **Schengen Visa**. These travel visas can be valid between one and five years and are renewable but they may not exceed the date of expiry of the passport. The Travel visa also lets students who have moved to another country after their studies in France to regularly return to France.

The Travel or Schengen Visa is for students who are from outside the EU/EEA and Switzerland. Students with the travel visa or Schengen visa can enter the 26 members states of the Schengen area as many times as they want. They may stay for a cumulative total of less than 90 days within the Schengen area over a six-month period. Holders of this travel visa may not work nor obtain a residency permit.

Working Holiday Visas

Some countries have reciprocal arrangements with France and students aged 18–30 from these countries can apply for a **Working Holiday Visa**. The countries are Argentina, Australia, Brazil, Canada, Chile, Colombia, South Korea, Hong Kong, Japan, Mexico, New Zealand, Russia, Taiwan and Uruguay.

Youth with this visa can spend one year in France without being enrolled in an institution for study and can work to supplement their finances. They do not need a residency permit while in France. This visa is not renewable except for Canadians. To obtain a working holiday visa, individuals must submit a request for a temporary long-stay visa or VLS-T.

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